THE SOCIABLE STAR

50

KARAN JOHAR, 50

FILMMAKER



Illustration by ARJAMA BANDYOPADHYAY

BECAUSE he has played a significant role in shaping the pop-culture sensibilities of India. In 2022, Dharma Production's theatrical hits included *Brahmastra: Part One – Shiva* and family comedy *Jugjugg Jeeyo*. Also, Dharmatic, the OTT arm of his studio, has helmed the hit show *The Fabulous Lives of Bollywood Wives* (2020—), whose third season was announced recently

BECAUSE he is living proof that directors can be stars too. Few Indian directors can boast an Instagram following of 15.3 million, being the face of several brands (five as of now) and becoming the talk of the town for their sartorial choices and interviews. Simply put, there's no escaping the ubiquitous KJo!

BECAUSE his banner continues to be a launchpad for new voices. Yes, it has a reputation for promoting "nepo babies", but Dharma has also launched many directors, including Ayan Mukerji, Shakun Batra (*Gehraiyaan*, 2022), Raj Mehta (*Good Newwz*, 2019) and Sharan Sharma (*Gunjan Saxena*, 2020). In 2023-24, it will back Collin D'Cunha (*Call Me Bae*) and Kayoze Irani

FRIENDS IN HIGH PLACES The sociable Johar's close friends include Gauri Khan, Farah Khan, Dharma CEO Apoorva Mehta and businesswomen Pooja and Aarti Shetty

BIG START As a young filmmaker, Johar assisted director Aditya Chopra in *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jaayenge* (1995)

By **M.G. Arun, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Suhani Singh, Kaushik Deka, Sonali Acharjee, Rahul Noronha, Ajay Sukumaran, Mohammad Waqas**